This refreshing soup can be prepared ahead and makes an elegant starter for a summer meal. For a lunch or dinner party, try serving it with smoked salmon.

cucumber and dill soup

SERVES 4 **PREP** 30 MINS PLUS 3HRS CHILLING **FREEZE** NOT SUITABLE

2 medium cucumbers
salt and pepper
1 quart (1 liter) whole or low-fat milk
small bunch of fresh dill
¼ cup plain yogurt

1 Peel the cucumbers, leaving one or two strips of skin on for color. Slice, put into a colander, and sprinkle with a teaspoon of salt. Toss and set it over a bowl for one hour. Meanwhile, put the milk in another bowl, add a few whole dill fronds, stir, and refrigerate for an hour to allow the flavors to infuse slightly.

2 Rinse the cucumber under cold running water, pressing down to extract as much moisture as possible. Remove the dill fronds from the milk. Put the milk and cucumber in a blender or food processor. Add a few more fronds of dill and some pepper and blend well. Pour into a bowl and refrigerate for 3 hours.

3 Place a sieve over a second bowl, pour in the chilled soup, and push through with the back of a wooden spoon, adding ½ cup–⅔ cup cold water, and return to the refrigerator until ready to serve.

4 Stir in the yogurt, taste, and adjust the seasoning if necessary. Whisk until frothy with a handheld or balloon whisk then pour into cups, bowls, or glasses. Decorate with a little more dill and serve immediately.